

Takeaways from the Goldman Sachs Private Company Software & Internet Conference

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We hosted the 5th annual Goldman Sachs Private Company Software & Internet conference in San Francisco from April 8-9. We heard directly from private companies, venture capitalists and other industry participants about the latest trends impacting the Internet landscape and summarize our key takeaways across Generative AI, the Creator Economy, Autonomous Vehicles, Food Delivery and Health & Wellness below.

Industry participants and venture capitalists at the conference were optimistic about the rapid adoption of generative AI applications, particularly as we move toward a phase of top-down implementation. While capacity was the initial focus, the industry is now turning toward efficiency and cost leverage, with panelists noting that an estimated ~\$7.5tr is expected to be spent on infrastructure by 2030. In addition, several companies discussed targeting operational leanness through AI - for instance, SuperOrdinary mentioned the headcount required to operate a beauty brand dropping from ~25 people down to ~3-5, and Eight Sleep requires proof AI cannot perform the role before opening a position.

A recurring theme was the displacement of deterministic enterprise software by agentic flows. Experts suggested that traditional systems of record may eventually be treated more like data warehouses, with agents building bespoke systems for specific business needs, such as replacing dashboards to navigate workflows on behalf of humans.

From a geopolitical perspective, industry participants predicted that over the next 5 years, as capacity constraints relieve, AI will be utilized as a primary mode for projecting global power and influence. In addition, it was noted that energy and chip infrastructure remain in a constrained state, representing a significant investing opportunity as the world remakes both digital and physical spaces with AI.

Key Takeaways

Users are Increasingly Turning to Generative AI Applications

Eleven Labs:

- Now at ~\$400m ARR, Eleven Labs is moving beyond simple text-to-speech models into contextual understanding, capturing emotion and dialect. The company is focused on how audio AI can be layered onto other modalities, such as applying voice to images or video, to create more immersive and personalized communication experiences.
- The company maintains profitability while scaling by allocating its resources (in terms of capital) into three roughly equal parts: 1) growth (building at the frontier of AI); 2) product; & 3) distribution.
- Longer term, the company spoke to a shift in enterprise communication, where businesses may use foundational voice models to transform how they communicate with both employees and customers across marketing, sales, and support.

RunwayML:

- RunwayML is pushing the boundaries of video generation with world models that can generate frames in under 100 milliseconds, with their technology allowing for real-time pivots during generation rather than rendering all frames upfront.
- While initially focused on media, entertainment, and game studios, Runway is expanding to individuals and teams who need surface-specific content (e.g., for Android or MacBook), allowing for highly personalized and tailored user experiences.
- The company predicts that within five years, over 50% of all content seen by users will be AI-generated, expanding their reach from media and entertainment into personalized content for various hardware surfaces.

Enabling the Growth of the Creator Economy

Patreon:

- Patreon is evolving into a primary destination for fans, with their focus shifting toward hosting media and communities directly within the app to foster deeper human connections. The company is addressing the friction of audience discovery through the addition of free membership options, allowing creators to build customer lists who can eventually be converted into paid superfans through direct engagement.
- Going forward, the company sees an opportunity to scale their user base by marketing directly to fans (which has historically been done by the creators themselves) - this includes an updated onboarding experience which includes displaying interest-based communities and recommendations.
- Despite the rise of AI-generated content, Patreon believes the value of human connection remains a durable and essential component of the economy that fans will continue to seek out and support.

SuperOrdinary:

- The company views creators as scalable, repeatable infrastructure for brands - this shift moves marketing away from traditional “pay-to-play” models toward cost-per-sales commission models.
- SuperOrdinary noted the rapid rise of social commerce in the US, building the infrastructure necessary for US brands to navigate platforms like TikTok. The company highlighted the use of AI livestreamers to maintain 24/7 engagement - brands can use human creators during peak times and switch to AI hosts during “dark hours” to ensure continuous interaction with consumers.
- Having built the necessary infrastructure, the company is shifting its capital allocation toward acquiring brands (similar to the LVMH/Sephora model), and optimizing them through their existing TikTok and social commerce layers.

Building Momentum in Autonomous Vehicle Deployment

May Mobility:

- As autonomous driving has progressed beyond proof of concept and is now commercially viable across multiple use cases, the AV industry is primarily focused on asset utilization as companies look to scale - striking a balance to grow fleet size in new cities while keeping utilization high.
- Looking ahead, the conversation underscored that the industry’s key challenges have shifted from pure R&D and towards building economically scalable systems. The main hurdles are now around building great ride hail solutions (i.e. demand aggregation, OEM partnerships, fleet management, financing). May Mobility is prioritizing a “Driver-as-a-Service” (DaaS) model through partnering with ride sharing platforms (i.e. UBER, LYFT) to solve for demand aggregation and fleet management.
- The discussion also reinforced that autonomy is a spectrum, with multiple technological paths capable of reaching commercial viability. May Mobility differentiated its approach from other operators (i.e. fully modular systems - Waymo; end-to-end approach - Tesla) to generalize more effectively to new scenarios.

Scaling Operations in Food Delivery Ecosystem

CookUnity:

- CookUnity acts as a comprehensive infrastructure layer that allows chefs to scale without upfront capital. The platform handles supply chain, packaging, and logistics, allowing chefs to focus solely on food quality. This infrastructure is also being extended into B2B segments, serving large enterprise clients through the centralized kitchen networks.
- The introduction of the Unity Pass subscription (which leverages health and personalization to drive higher retention) has led to a massive lift in customer frequency and AOV, with approximately 15% of customers already on this plan.

- The company is investing in automation for plating, packaging, and picking to drive further revenue opportunities. Looking ahead 3-5 years, they view increasing variety as the highest ROI driver for dollar retention and market expansion.

Convergence of Wearables and Intervention in Health & Wellness

Eight Sleep:

- Eight Sleep is evolving from a hardware provider to a “wearable plus” company, using its Pod hardware to track biometrics and intervene through temperature and elevation adjustments. The company is leveraging AI to create digital twins based on sleep data to provide predictive health analytics and biological age assessments, as well as building integrations with wearable companies (incl. Whoop/Oura).
- In terms of the broader market opportunity, they are beginning to extend their marketing messaging to reach more user cohorts (beyond their initial target audience of men and performance athletes) - for example, Eight Sleep introduced a hot flash mode for women going through menopause in addition to several affordability initiatives (offering Buy Now, Pay Later, rental options, etc.).
- In addition to scaling their global reach, Eight Sleep is expanding its TAM by seeking FDA approval for apnea detection to be able to target clinical environments like hospitals and elder care facilities.